ZANDER

Startup Foundations Kit

Everything You Need to Launch with Structure

A ZANDER SYSTEMS PUBLICATION

Operating Simply Methodology

$99

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01

Business Planning Fundamentals

From idea to execution plan

Startup Foundations Kit

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Legal Foundations

Protect yourself from day one

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03

Financial Projections

12-month and 3-year models

1. Before You Begin: The Readiness Assessment
2. Business Plan Essentials
3. Legal Foundation Checklist
4. Financial Projections Template
5. Go-To-Market Framework
6. Founder's Operating Manual
7. First 90 Days Roadmap
8. Common Mistakes to Avoid

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Go-to-Market Strategy

Launch with purpose, not hope

The Honest Self-Assessment

Before you quit your job or invest your savings, answer these questions honestly:

Market Validation

- ☐ Have you talked to 20+ potential customers?
- ☐ Have at least 5 said they would pay for your solution?
- ☐ Do you understand WHY they would pay?
- ☐ Have you identified who will NOT buy and why?

Personal Readiness

- ☐ Can you survive 12-18 months without income?
- ☐ Does your family/support system understand the commitment?
- ☐ Are you prepared to work harder than you ever have?
- ☐ Can you handle rejection, failure, and uncertainty?

Skills & Resources

- ☐ Do you have the core skills to build version 1?
- ☐ Do you know what skills you're missing?
- ☐ Do you have a network to tap for advice?
- ☐ Can you sell your product/service yourself?

Scoring:

- 12+ checks: You're ready. Execute.
- 8-11 checks: Address the gaps first.
- Under 8 checks: More preparation needed.

The Problem Worth Solving

Fill in this template:

```
I am building [PRODUCT/SERVICE]
for [SPECIFIC TARGET CUSTOMER]
who have [SPECIFIC PROBLEM].
```

```
Unlike [CURRENT ALTERNATIVES],
my solution [KEY DIFFERENTIATOR].

I know this because [EVIDENCE/VALIDATION].
```

If you can't complete this clearly, you're not ready to start.

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Brand Foundation

More than just a logo

The One-Page Business Plan

Skip the 50-page plans nobody reads. Cover these elements on a single page:

VISION Where is this company in 10 years? What's the big dream?

MISSION What do we do, for whom, and why does it matter?

VALUES 3-5 non-negotiable principles that guide every decision.

PROBLEM What specific pain point are we solving?

SOLUTION How do we solve it better than alternatives?

CUSTOMER Who is our ideal customer? Be specific.

REVENUE MODEL How do we make money? Be clear.

KEY METRICS What 3-5 numbers tell us if we're winning?

COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE Why will we win? What's hard to copy?

TEAM Who's building this? What makes us the right people?

The Lean Canvas (Template)

```
┌──────────────────┬──────────────────┬──────────────────┐
|     PROBLEM      |   SOLUTION       | UNIQUE VALUE     |
| Top 3 problems   | Top 3 features   |  PROPOSITION     |
|                  |                  | Single, clear    |
|                  |                  | message          |
├──────────────────┼──────────────────┼──────────────────┤
|  KEY METRICS     |                  |   UNFAIR         |
| Key activities   |   CHANNELS       |   ADVANTAGE      |
| you measure      | Path to          | Can't be easily  |
|                  | customers        | copied/bought    |
├──────────────────┼──────────────────┼──────────────────┤
|  COST STRUCTURE              |  REVENUE STREAMS       |
|  Customer acquisition        |  Revenue model         |
|  Distribution                |  Lifetime value        |
|  People                      |  Margins               |
└──────────────────────────────┴────────────────────────┘
```

06

Entity Structure

Choose the right business type

Entity Selection Guide

STRUCTURE	BEST FOR	LIABILITY	TAX	COMPLEXITY
Sole Prop	Testing ideas	None	Personal	Minimal
LLC	Most startups	Protected	Flexible	Low
S-Corp	Profitable businesses	Protected	Pass-through	Medium
C-Corp	Raising VC	Protected	Double	High

Recommendation: Start with an LLC unless you know you're raising institutional capital.

Formation Checklist

Checklist

- [ ] Choose business name (check availability)
- [ ] Register with state (Articles of Organization/Incorporation)
- [ ] Get EIN from IRS (free, irs.gov)
- [ ] Open business bank account
- [ ] Draft operating agreement (LLC) or bylaws (Corp)
- [ ] Register for state taxes if applicable
- [ ] Check local business license requirements
- [ ] Get necessary permits for your industry
- [ ] Set up registered agent service

- [ ] Create cap table if multiple founders

Founder Agreement Must-Haves

If you have co-founders, document these BEFORE you start:

1. **Equity split** - Who owns what percentage?
2. **Vesting schedule** - Usually 4 years with 1-year cliff
3. **Role clarity** - Who's CEO? Who decides what?
4. **IP assignment** - All work belongs to the company
5. **Decision rights** - Voting thresholds for major decisions
6. **Exit provisions** - What happens if someone leaves?
7. **Non-compete** - Reasonable restrictions
8. **Dispute resolution** - How do you handle disagreements?

Essential Legal Documents

Priority order for most startups:

1. Terms of Service / Service Agreement
2. Privacy Policy (required if collecting any data)
3. Employee/Contractor Agreement Template
4. NDA Template (use sparingly)
5. Website Terms of Use
6. Intellectual Property Assignment

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Founding Documents

Essential paperwork checklist

The Startup Financial Model

You need three views: Monthly (Year 1), Quarterly (Years 2-3), Annual (Years 4-5)

Revenue Projections Template

```
REVENUE ASSUMPTIONS
____________________________________________________

Product/Service: _____________
Price Point: $_____________
Sales Cycle: _____________ days

Customer Acquisition:
  Month 1-3: _____ customers/month
  Month 4-6: _____ customers/month
  Month 7-12: _____ customers/month

Churn Rate: _____%/month
Upsell Rate: _____%/month

MONTHLY REVENUE PROJECTION
____________________________________________________

Month   New Cust.   Total Cust.   Revenue
1       _____       _____         $_____
2       _____       _____         $_____
3       _____       _____         $_____
...
12      _____       _____         $_____
```

Expense Categories

Fixed Costs (monthly)

- Rent/co-working: $____
- Software subscriptions: $____
- Insurance: $____
- Accounting/Legal retainer: $____
- Founder salaries (if any): $____

Variable Costs (per transaction/customer)

- Cost of goods sold: $____
- Payment processing: ____%
- Customer acquisition cost: $____
- Hosting/infrastructure per user: $____

Cash Flow Management

The #1 startup killer is running out of cash. Track this weekly:

```
WEEKLY CASH POSITION
____________________________________________________

Starting Cash: $_____
+ Revenue received: $_____
- Expenses paid: $_____
= Ending Cash: $_____

Weeks of runway remaining: _____ weeks
```

Break-Even Analysis

```
Fixed Costs per Month: $_____
Gross Margin per Sale: $_____%

Break-Even Sales = Fixed Costs ÷ Gross Margin %
                 = $_____ ÷ _____%
                 = $_____ per month

Break-Even Customers = $_____ ÷ Average Sale Price
                     = _____ customers per month
```

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The 90-Day Launch Roadmap

Week by week action items

Finding Your First 10 Customers

Forget marketing automation. Your first customers come from:

1. **Your network** - Who do you already know?
2. **Their network** - Who can they introduce you to?
3. **Communities** - Where does your ideal customer hang out?
4. **Direct outreach** - Who can you contact directly?
5. **Content** - What can you share that attracts them?

The Customer Acquisition Stack

Start simple. Add complexity only when you've maxed out the simple stuff.

Level 1: Manual & Free

- Personal outreach (email, LinkedIn, phone)
- Content on social platforms you own
- Speaking at events/podcasts
- Referrals from existing customers

Level 2: Paid & Scalable

- Search ads (Google, Bing)
- Social ads (LinkedIn, Meta, Twitter)
- Content marketing + SEO
- Partnerships and affiliates

Level 3: Team & Process

- Dedicated sales team
- Marketing automation
- ABM campaigns
- PR and media

Pricing Strategy

The Pricing Framework:

1. **Cost-Plus:** Your cost + margin = price
    - Pro: Simple, guaranteed margin
    - Con: Ignores value to customer
2. **Competitive:** Match or beat alternatives
    - Pro: Easy to explain
    - Con: Race to bottom
3. **Value-Based:** Price based on customer outcome
    - Pro: Higher margins possible
    - Con: Requires deep customer understanding

Recommendation: Start with value-based. If your solution saves a customer $10,000/year, charging $1,000 is a no-brainer.

Launch Checklist

Checklist

- [ ] Landing page live and tested
- [ ] Payment processing working
- [ ] Onboarding flow documented
- [ ] Support email/chat ready
- [ ] Analytics tracking installed
- [ ] 10 beta users confirmed
- [ ] Beta feedback incorporated
- [ ] FAQ/documentation ready
- [ ] Announcement drafted (email, social)
- [ ] Friends/family ready to amplify
- PR outreach if applicable

- [ ] Announcement posted everywhere
- [ ] Personal outreach to top prospects
- [ ] Monitor for bugs/issues
- [ ] Respond to every comment/question
- [ ] Celebrate (briefly)
- [ ] Follow up with all leads
- [ ] Interview first customers
- [ ] Document what's working/not
- [ ] Iterate based on feedback
- [ ] Plan next sprint

Daily Non-Negotiables

Morning Routine (30 min)

- Review yesterday's numbers
- Identify ONE priority for today
- Clear urgent messages only

End-of-Day Routine (15 min)

- Log progress/learnings
- Update to-do list for tomorrow
- Send any critical communications

Weekly Rhythm

DAY	FOCUS
Monday	Planning & priorities
Tuesday	Customer/sales focused
Wednesday	Product/operations
Thursday	Team & partnerships
Friday	Review & reflection

Decision-Making Framework

For every significant decision, ask:

1. **Is this reversible?** If yes, decide fast and iterate.
2. **What's the cost of being wrong?** If low, experiment.
3. **Who's affected?** Consult them, but don't require consensus.
4. **What would I tell a friend?** Trust your instincts.

Energy Management

Your energy is your most valuable asset.

Protect it:

- Say no to 80% of requests
- Batch similar tasks together
- Schedule deep work, not just meetings
- Take real breaks (lunch, weekends)

Replenish it:

- Sleep 7+ hours
- Exercise 3+ times per week
- Maintain relationships outside work
- Have hobbies that aren't "productive"

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Days 1-30: Foundation

Goals:

- Complete all legal/financial setup
- Validate problem with 20+ customer conversations
- Build MVP or service prototype
- Get first paying customer

Weekly Focus:

- Week 1: Entity setup, bank account, basic website
- Week 2: 10 customer interviews
- Week 3: 10 more interviews, start building
- Week 4: MVP complete, first pitch to real customer

Days 31-60: Traction

Goals:

- 5-10 paying customers
- Understand CAC and LTV basics
- Identify primary acquisition channel
- Establish weekly rhythm

Weekly Focus:

- Week 5: Launch MVP, get feedback
- Week 6: Iterate based on feedback
- Week 7: Double down on what's working
- Week 8: Document processes, prepare to scale

Days 61-90: Scale Foundation

Goals:

- Clear path to 10x customers
- Documented processes for core operations

- Financial model validated
- Growth plan for next 90 days

Weekly Focus:

- Week 9: Analyze first 60 days data
- Week 10: Optimize conversion funnel
- Week 11: Build growth experiments backlog
- Week 12: Plan next quarter, celebrate wins

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The Top 10 Startup Killers

1. **Building without validation**
   - Fix: Talk to 20 customers before writing code
2. **Running out of cash**
   - Fix: Know your runway, cut costs early
3. **Wrong co-founder**
   - Fix: Work together before committing
4. **Hiring too fast**
   - Fix: Do it yourself first, hire only when desperate
5. **Not charging enough**
   - Fix: Raise prices until customers complain, then back off slightly
6. **Ignoring metrics**
   - Fix: Define 3 numbers that matter, track weekly
7. **Scaling before product-market fit**
   - Fix: Don't spend on growth until retention is strong
8. **Perfectionism**
   - Fix: Ship, learn, iterate
9. **Not asking for help**
   - Fix: Build advisor network, join communities
10. **Burning out**
    - Fix: Marathon not sprint, protect your energy

Red Flags to Watch

In your business:

- Customers churning faster than you acquire
- Consistently missing revenue projections
- Team turnover above 30% annually
- Avoiding looking at financials

In yourself:

- Dreading going to work
- Lying awake worrying every night
- Damaging important relationships
- Using substances to cope

When to Pivot vs. Persist

Pivot when:

- Customers won't pay after extensive iteration
- Market fundamentally shifts
- You discover a better opportunity
- Team is misaligned on direction

Persist when:

- You're making progress, just slowly
- Customers love the product but you need more of them
- Competition validates the market
- You still believe and have runway

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Recommended Reading

- "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries
- "Zero to One" by Peter Thiel
- "The Mom Test" by Rob Fitzpatrick
- "Atomic Habits" by James Clear

Tools We Recommend

- **Legal:** Stripe Atlas, Clerky, or local attorney
- **Banking:** Mercury, Brex, or local credit union
- **Accounting:** QuickBooks Online, Xero
- **CRM:** HubSpot (free), Pipedrive
- **Project Management:** Notion, Linear

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We help startups build the systems they need to scale. From day-one foundations to growth-stage operations, our consulting and platform combine hands-on expertise with AI-powered tools.

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Operating Simply

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